Great Indian Migration Wave today operates less on indenture and nomenclature and more on a kith-kin based notion of adventure.

Railway Manic and Postal Magic

The railways played an important role in facilitating the Great Indian Migration Wave, but this was remarkably unforeseen at the time of its inception. During the hectic rounds of lobbying by private British companies in the 1840s, it was observed that Indians were ‘poor’ and ‘thinly scattered over extensive tracts of country’ and that revenue from railway services would be drawn mainly from goods traffic and ‘not from passengers’.[76] Nothing could be further from the truth. In the first 100 years of the railways after its inauguration in 1853, annual earnings from passenger traffic were greater or almost equal to the earning from goods traffic.[77] Annual passenger traffic grew exponentially from 13 million in 1865 to 250 million in 1905 and over a billion in 1946, faster than the growth in population or size of the track network.[78] This fact, however, did not change the material conditions of travel in the Indian train and 90 per cent of passengers travelled in badly ventilated third-class carriages, tolerating the congestion in reward for speed.[79] A third-class carriage usually had fifty-six seats with each passenger getting less than seventeen inches of sitting space when twenty inches was thought to be permissible.[80] Toilets appeared in these carriages only in the 1900s.[81] For some decades, passengers were made to cram into goods wagons with livestock during peak traffic, even after the practice was banned in Britain.[82]

The blame for the disorderliness was inevitably passed on to the Indians. In 1929, journalist H. Sutherland Stark wrote a piece called ‘Educating the Third-Class Passenger’ which noted that Indians would ‘hurl themselves at a half-open doorway in a suicidal effort to board a moving train’ and were ‘insufficiently taught how to travel like sane human beings’.[83] As a long-time traveller on the Indian Railways, I share some sympathies with such stark observations, but in reality the supply of services consistently fell short of the demand. Not surprisingly, this was one of the first issues